

SCARS - NO MORE A PROBLEM

Scars are a natural part of the body's healing process. A scar results from the biologic process of wound repair on the skin and other tissues. Scars can also develop from surgery, infections like chickenpox or skin conditions like acne. Scar formation depends on factors like disturbed blood supply, infection, wound dressing, medication, trauma, location, duration of healing, age and inherited tendency of an individual to develop scars.

Types of Scars:

The etiology, location and healing course of the wound result in different scar types. The most common types of scars are hypertrophic scars, keloids, atrophic scars and scar contracture.

Hypertrophic scars: They may occur after surgery, accident and burn injury on the trunk, extremities, joint or any other part of the body. These are scars that remain within the boundaries of the wound, sometimes regressing spontaneously after the initial injury. They are often red, inflamed, itchy and even painful.

Keloids: In contrast to hypertrophic scars, keloids extend beyond the original boundaries of the wounds and infiltrate the surrounding healthy tissue. Keloids occur on areas where the skin is under tension such as ear lobes, back, shoulders and chest. Keloids are more likely to occur in women, and in people with dark skin. Keloids may be itchy and painful.

Atrophic scars: These types of scars appear on skin that are prone to excessive production of sebum and are basically oily in nature (Acne Scars). There are many types of atrophic scars, ranging from deep pits to scars that are angular or wavelike in appearance.

Scar contracture: Burns or other injuries resulting in the loss of a large area of skin may form a scar that pulls the edges of the skin together resulting in, a contractile wound- healing process. The contracture may affect the adjacent tissues, restricting normal movement.

Management of Scars

Scars could be managed by three methods - leave alone management, non- invasive and invasive treatment options.

Leave alone management: Most scars are best left

to mature before any diagnosis is made on their appearance. Some scars over a period of time develop into hypertrophic scars which require further assessment in terms of appearance, symptoms and psychological impact. Some scars are best left alone in the long term when they don't restrict movement and cause discomfort.

Non-invasive treatment: This method includes use of over-the-counter or prescription creams, ointments or gels. This mode of treatment is generally free of side effects and complications. The use of acrylic casts, static and dynamic splints, application of a variety of oils, lotions, compression therapy with or without silicon sheet and gels like Contractubex® can be used to treat scars caused by surgical incisions or other injuries or wounds. Contractubex® is one of the clinically proven and effective non-invasive treatment for scar management.

Contractubex®- specific treatment for scars and keloids

For many years now, Contractubex® has been found to be very effective in treating cosmetically disfiguring and movement restricting scars. The gel can be used to treat both old (less than 1 year) and recent scars. Contractubex® is generally well tolerated, even during long-term treatment. Local skin reactions and side effects are very rare. Hypertrophic and keloidal scars, movement restricting and cosmetically disfiguring scars after operations, accidents, traumatic tendon contractures can all be effectively treated with Contractubex®.

Invasive treatments: Invasive treatments that have been advocated with variable outcomes include injections of fluorouracil, interferon gamma and bleomycin, radiotherapy, laser therapy, although their repetition may cause adverse reactions like redness, itching and irritation on sensitive skin. Surgical Scar Revision, Dermabrasion, Laser Resurfacing and Pulsed Dye Laser, Soft Tissue Fillers (collagen injections or fat transfer) and Chemical Peels are some of the other options for scar management.

Conclusion

Non-invasive treatments are fast emerging as the winner as compared to invasive surgery due to cost factors and less side effects. Patients prefer non-invasive options for treatment of scars and they are also the first line of treatment for the scar management.

For further information
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